

Take Full Responsibility: Wrap-Up, Featuring Katy Kvalvik

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Leaders must practice, just like Coach Summitt and her teams practiced. Practice becomes even more important when you're exhausted, isolated, and feeling less confident. It's about consistently doing the things that point you back to measurable and meaningful outcomes.

Even when you don't feel like it, or you don't have all the answers, consistently putting these principles into practice will create and reinforce a culture of full responsibility. If you study success long enough and closely enough, when mediocrity starts to creep in, you can identify and address it early. In the assessment phase, if you set specific goals, boundaries, and standards of behavior that facilitate the outcomes you want for yourself and others, you and your team will begin to develop an appetite for full responsibility.

Accountability is essential to personal growth, as well as team growth. How can you improve if you're never wrong? If you don't admit a mistake and take responsibility for it, you're bound to make the same one again. You learn as much from getting it wrong as you do from getting it right. But you must be willing to take responsibility for failure and be willing to examine it closely no matter how excruciating or embarrassing.

Ask this question: What does success look and feel like on my team, in my company, in my life?

What's the customer experience like? What's the product cycle like? How do the teams behave? What are my performance review scores like?"

Maybe at this point you are silently saying, "But, Katy, you don't understand. I don't have a team that I can trust." I understand. Taking full responsibility means that everyone on the team has to be committed to doing the work, upholding the standards, or whatever else it is that you've identified as the driver of success.

As a leader, ask yourself this question: Do I have the right team? If not, what criteria would make up the right team? What courageous steps do I need to take to get the right team in place? When am I going to start taking those steps?

As a team member, ask yourself if you're contributing to the mission of your organization. Are you part of a high-functioning team that delivers results and contributes to the overall success of the organization? If not, what steps could you take to make a greater contribution?

Whether you're a leader of a large unit or a team member on a very small team, it is up to each of us to take full responsibility.